FICTION

The Disguising at Hertford

Lydgate, John

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THE DISGUISING AT HERTFORD

By John Lydgate

c.1370 - 1449

A verse play written circa 1427.

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For the purposes of this multi-platform electronic text, the medieval 'thorn' (a character representing 'th') has been changed to 'th'. It was impracticable to reproduce the original punctuation, which mainly consisted of the virgule or slash. Modern commas and full stops have been sparingly imposed. Superscript tildes and mid-script tildes have been removed. Mid-script dots have been changed to colons as they seem to indicate a deliberate suspension. The last four words of the initial rubric (Brys : slayne at Loviers) appear to have been added to the manuscript at a date slightly later than when it was first written. Section marks occur in the original without consistency; where these clearly indicate a new section, a blank line has been inserted to produce a similar effect.

The endnotes include the original stage directions. Two lacunae in the manuscript have been supplied by reference to John Stow's late 16th- century manuscript copy of the text. The other endnotes are glosses of particular words in the text.

The transcription of Lydgate's text has also been published in book form under the title 'Lydgate's Disguising at Hertford Castle', including a modern verse translation of the text, an editor's introduction and notes, and a study of the literary and historical background of the play and of its first performance, which took place at Hertford Castle as part of the royal Christmas festivities of, probably, 1427. It is hoped that this additional material will become available as a Project Gutenberg etext. Readers interested in the book may wish to have its publication details

Lydgate's Disguising at Hertford Castle by Derek Forbes with Foreword by Glynne Wickham First published by Blot Publishing, Pulborough, 1998. Pp. xiv + 82, f'piece, and 4 plate ills. Decorated and laminated card cover. ISBN 1 900929 03 1. Retail price in 2000 six pounds GBP.

Copies of the book are available from Blot Publishing, 8 Chanctonbury, Ashington, West Sussex, RH20 3QE, UK. Telephone: +44 (0)1903 893806 Email: <info@blot.co.uk>; Web site: <http://www.blot.co.uk>. or from the Society for Theatre Research, c/o The Theatre Museum, 1E Tavistock Street, London WC2E 7PA, UK.

Copies of the book were distributed by the Society for Theatre Research to its members worldwide in 1998, and can be consulted in the libraries of institutions which subscribe to the Society.

THE DISGUISING AT HERTFORD

Nowe folowethe here the maner of a bille by wey of supplicacon putte to the kyng holding his noble feest of Cristmasse in the Castel of Hertford as in a disguysing : of the Rude upplandisshe people compleyning on hir wyves with the boystous aunswere of hir wyves devysed by lydegate at the Request of the Countre Roullour Brys : slayne at Loviers

Most noble prynce : With support of your grace, Ther beon entred : in to youre royal place And late coomen in to youre castell, Youre poure lieges, wheche lyke no thing weel. Nowe in the vigyle of this nuwe yeere Certayne sweynes, ful [froward of ther chere], Of entent comen, [fallen on ther kne], For to compleyne vn to yuoure magestee Vpon the mescheef of gret aduersytee, Vpon the trouble and the cruweltee 10 Which that they haue endured in theyre lyves By the felnesse of theyre fierce wyves, Which is a tourment verray importable, A bonde of sorowe, a knott vnremuwable. For whoo is bounde or locked in maryage, Yif he beo olde, he falleth in dotage, And yong folkes, of theyre lymes sklendre, Grene and lusty, and of brawne but tendre, Phylosophres callen in suche aage A Chylde to wyve, a woodnesse or a raage. 20

For they afferme ther is noon eorthly stryff May beo compared to wedding of a wyff, And who that euer stondethe in the cas He with his Rebecke may sing ful oft ellas, Lyke as theos hynes, here stonding oon by oon, He may with hem vpon the daunce goon. Leorne the traas, boothe at even and morowe Of Karycantowe in tourment and in sorowe.... Weyle the while ellas that he was borne. For Obbe, the Reeve, that goothe heere al to forne, 30 He pleynethe sore, his mariage is not meete, For his wyff, Beautryce Bittersweete, Cast vpon him an hougly cheer ful rowghe Whane he komethe home, ful wery frome the ploughe, With hungry stomake, deed and paale of cheere, In hope to fynde redy his dynier.

Thanne sittethe Beautryce, bolling at the nale, As she that gyvethe of him no maner tale. For she alday with hir iowsy nolle, Hathe for the collyk pouped in the bolle 40 And for heed aache : with pepir and gynger Dronk dolled ale, to make hir throte cleer, And komethe hir hoome, whane hit drawethe to eve. And thanne Robyn, the cely poure Reeve, Fynde noone amendes of harome ne damage But leene growell, and soupethe cold potage, And of his wyf hathe noone other cheer But cokkrowortes vn to his souper. This is his servyce sitting at the borde, And cely Robyn, yif he speke a worde, 50 Beautryce of him doothe so lytel rekke That with hir distaff she hittethe him in the nekke, For a medecyne to chawf with his bloode. With suche a metyerde she hathe shape him an hoode.

And Colyn Cobeller, folowing his felawe, Hathe hade his part of the same lawe, For by the fayth that the preost him gaf His wyff hathe taught him to pleyne at the staff. Hir quarter strooke were so large and rounde That on his rigge the towche was alwey founde. 60

Cecely Sourechere, his owen precyous spouse, Kowde him reheete whan he came to house. Yif he ought spake whanne he felt peyne, Ageyne oon worde alweys he hade tweyne. Sheo qwytt him euer, ther was no thing to seeche, Six for oon, of worde and

strookes eeche. Ther was no meen bytweene hem for to goone. What euer he wan : clowting olde shoone The wykday, pleynely this is no tale, Sheo wolde on Sondayes drynk it at the nale. 70 His part was noon, he sayde not oonys nay. Hit is no game, but an hernest play For lack of wit a man his wyf to greeve. Theos housbondemen : who so wolde hem leeve, Koude yif they dourst telle : in Audyence, What folowethe ther of wyves to doone offence. Is noon so olde ne ryveld on hir face, Wit tong or staff but that she dare manase. Mabyle, God hir sauve and blesse, Koude yif hir list bere here of witnesse, 80 Wordes, strookes vnhappe, and harde grace, With sharp nayles kracching in the face. I mene thus, whane the distaff is brooke With theyre fistes wyves wol be wrooke.

Blessed thoo men that cane in suche offence Meekly souffre, take al in pacyence Tendure suche wyfly purgatorye. Heven for theyre meede, to regne ther in glorye. God graunt al housbandes that beon in this place To wynne so heven for his hooly grace. 90

Nexst in ordre, this bochier stoute and bolde That killed hathe bulles and boores olde, This Berthilmew, for al his broode knyff, Yit durst he neuer with his sturdy wyff In no mater holde chaumpartye. And if he did, sheo wolde anoon defye His pompe, his pryde, with a sterne thought, And sodeynly setten him at nought. Thoughe his bely were rounded lyche an ooke She wolde not fail to gyf the first strooke. 100 For proude Pernelle lyche a Chaumpyon Wolde leve hir puddinges in a gret Cawdroun, Suffre hem boylle and taake of hem noon heede, But with hir skumour reeche him on the heued. Shee wolde paye him and make no delaye, Bid him goo pleye him a twenty deuel way. She was no cowarde founde at suche a neode, Hir fist ful offt made his cheekis bleed. What querell euer that he agenst hir sette, She cast hir not to dyen in his dette. 110 She made no taylle, but qwytt him by and by. His quarter sowde, she payde him feythfully. And his waages, wt al hir best entent, She made ther of noon assignement.

Eeke Thome Tynker, with alle hees pannes olde And alle the wyres of Banebury that he solde, His styth, his hamour, his bagge portatyf, Bare vp his arme whane he faught with his wyff: He foonde for haste no better bokeller, Vpon his cheeke the distaff came so neer. 120 Hir name was cleped Tybot Tapister. To brawle and broyle she nad no maner fer, To thakke his pilche stoundemel nowe and thanne Thikker thane Thome koude clowten any panne.

Nexst Colle Tyler, ful hevy of his cheer, Compleynethe on Phelyce his wyff the wafurer Al his bred with sugre nys not baake, Yit on his cheekis some tyme he hathe a caake So hoot and nuwe, or he can taken heede, That his heres glowe verray reede 130 For a medecyne whane the forst is colde, Makyng his teethe to ratle that beon oolde.

This is the compleynt that theos dotardes oolde Make on theyre wyves that beon so stoute and bolde, Theos holy martirs preued ful pacyent, Lowly beseching, in al hir best entent, Vnto youre noble ryal magestee, To graunte hem fraunchyse and also liberte Sith they beothe fetird and bounden in maryage, A saufconduct to sauf him frome damage. 140 Eeke vnder support of youre hyeghe renoun Graunt hem also a

proteccyoun.

Conquest of wyves is rone thoroughe this lande, Cleyming of Right to haue the hyegher hande. But if you list, of youre Regallye, The olde testament for to modefye, And that yee list asselen theyre request That theos poure husbandes might lyf in rest, And that theyre wyves in theyre felle might Wol medle amonge mercy with theyre right. 150 For it came neuer of nature ne raysoun A lyonesse toppresse the lyoun, Ner a wolfesse for al hir thyraunye Ouer the wolf to haven the maystrye. Ther beon nowe wolfesses moo thane twoo or three The bookys recorde, wheeche tht yonder bee. Seothe to this mater of mercy and of grace, And or thees dotardes parte out of this place, Vpon theyre compleynt to shape remedye, Or they beo likly to stande in iupardye. 160 It is no game with wyves for to pleye, But for foolis, that gif no force to deye.

Takethe heed of thaunswer of the wyves.

Touching the substance of this hyeghe discorde, We six wyves : beon ful of oon acorde, Yif worde and chyding may vs not avaylle We wol darrein it in chaumpcloos by bataylle, Iupart oure right laate or ellys raathe. And for oure partye, the worthy Wyff of Bathe Cane shewe statutes moo than six of seven Howe wyves make hir housbandes wynne heven, 170 Maugre the feonde and al his vyolence. For theyre vertu of parfyte pacyence Partenethe not to wyves nowe adayes, Sauf on theyre housbandes for to make assayes. Ther pacyence was buryed long agoo, Gresyldes story recordethe pleinly soo.

It longethe to vs to clappen as a mylle, No counseyle keepe, but the trouth oute telle. We beo not borne by hevenly influence Of oure nature to keepe vs in sylence. 180 For this is no doute, euery prudent wyff Hathe redy aunswere in al suche maner stryff, Thoughe theos dotardes, with theyre dokked berdes Which strowtethe out as they were made of herdes, Haue ageyn hus a gret quarell nowe sette. I trowe the bakoun was neuer of hem fette Awaye at Dounmowe in the Pryorye. They weene of vs to haue ay the maystrye. Ellas theos fooles let hem aunswere here to, Whoo cane hem wasshe, who can hem wring alsoo, 190 Wryng hem, yee wryng, so als god vs speed, Til that some tyme we make hir nases bleed, And sowe hir cloothes whane they beothe to rent, And clowte hir bakkes til some of vs beo shent. Loo yit theos fooles, god gyf hem sory chaunce, Wolde sette hir wyves vnder gouuernaunce, Make vs to hem for to lowte lowe: We knowe to weel the bent of Iackys bowe. Al that we clayme, we clayme it but of right. Yif they say nay let preve it out by ffight. 200 We wil vs grounde not vpon womanhede. Fy on hem, cowardes. When hit komethe to nede, We clayme maystrye by prescripcyoun, Be long tytle of successyoun Frome wyff to wyff, which we wol not leese. Men may weel gruchche, but they shal not cheese. Custume is vs for nature and vsaunce To set oure housbandes lyf in gret noysaunce. Humbelly byseching nowe at oon worde Vn to oure liege, and moost souerein lord, 210 Vs to defende of his regallye, And of his grace susteenen oure partye, Requering the statuyt of olde antiquytee That in youre tyme it may confermed bee.

The complaynte of the lewed housbandes wt the cruwell aunswers of theyre wyves herde, the kyng yivethe ther vpon sentence and iugement.

This noble Prynce, moost royal of estate, Having an eyeghe to this mortal debate, First aduerting of ful hyeghe prudence, Wil vnavysed gyve here no sentence With oute counseylle of haste to procede By sodeyne doome, for he takythe heede 220 To eyther partye as iuge indifferent, Seing the paryll of hasty iugement. Pourposithe him in this contynude stryffe To gif no sentence ther of diffynytyff Til ther beo made examynacyoun Of other partye, and inquysicyoun. He considerethe, and makethe Raysoun his guyde, As egal iuge enclyning to noo syde. Not with standing, he hathe compassyoun Of the poure housbandes trybulacyoun, 230 So afft arrested with theyre wyves rokkes Which of theyre distaves haue so many knokkes, Peysing also in his regallye The lawe tht wymmen allegge for theyre partye, Custume, Nature and eeke prescripcyoun, Statuyt vsed by confirmacyoun, Processe and daate of tyme oute of mynde, Recorde of Cronycles, witnesse of hir kuynde. Wher fore the Kyng wol al this nexst yeere That wyves fraunchyse : stonde hoole and entier, 240 And that no man withstonde it ne withdrawe, Til man may fynde some pcesse oute by lawe That they shoulde by nature in theyre lyves Haue soueraynteе on theyre prudent wyves, A thing vnkouthe, which was neuer founde. Let men be ware ther fore, or they beo bounde. The bonde is hard, who soo that lookethe weel. Some man were leuer fetterd beon in steel. Raunsoun might help his peyne to aswaage, But whoo is wedded lyuethe euer in suage. 250 And I knowe neuer, nowher fer ner neer, Man that was gladde to bynde him prysonier, Thoughe that his prysoun, his castell, or his holde Wer depeynted with asure or with golde.

Explicit.

GLOSSARY, STAGE DIRECTIONS, NOTES

line 5 vigyle of this nuwe yeere = this new year's eve 6 froward of ther chere: lacuna made up from Stow 7 fallen on ther kne: lacuna made up from Stow 13 importable = unbearable 16 dotage = feeble-mindedness 20 woodnesse = madness 24 Rebecke = fiddle; ellas = alas! 25 stage direction - demonstrando vj Rusticos 27 traas = course 28 possible lacuna follows here? 37 bolling at the nale = quaffing at the ale-house 39 iowsy nolle = juicy noddle 40 pouped = gulped 42 dolled = mulled 44 cely = silly, i.e. simple, innocent 45 harome = harm 46 growell = gruel 48 cokkrowortes = stale brew-mash 53 to chawf with his bloode = to chafe his blood with 54 metyerde = meteyard or yardstick 55 stage direction - demonstrando pictaciarium 57 preost = priest 60 rigge = back 62 reheete = attack, scold 65 qwytt = requited; ther was no thing to seeche = it was plain to see 67 meen = middle way 68 wan = earned; clowting = mending 71 oonys = once 74 leeve = believe 77 ryveld = shrivelled 78 Wit = with; manase = menace 79 Mabyle = Mary 80 Koude yif hir list = could if it please her 84 wol be wrooke = will wreak revenge 85 thoo men = those men 87 Tendure = to endure 88 meede = reward 90 so = to? 91 stage direction - demonstrando Carnificem 95 holde chaumpartye = divide power, or resist 104 skumour = skimmer; reeche = strike; heued = head 111 qwytt him by and by = repaid him in due time 112 quarter sowde = surrender sued for 113 wt = with 115 stage direction - demonstrando the Tynker 117 styth = anvil 119 bokeller = buckler, shield 121 cleped = called 122 she nad no maner fer = she feared not 123 thakke his pilche = thwack

his great-coat; stoundemel = sometimes 124 Thikker = more stoutly 126 wafurer = waferer, i.e. pastry-cook 129 or = ere 130 heres = ears 135 preued = proved 139 fetird = fettered 140 him = them 145 Regallye = regality 147 that yee list = if you please; asselen = authorize 150 medle = mingle 153 thyraunye = tyranny 156 tht = that; stage direction - distaves 157 Seothe = see 162 that gif no force = that are of no consequence 166 darrein = decide; chaumpcloos = tilting-field 167 Iupart = imperil; raathe = soon 169 of = or 171 Maugre the feonde = in spite of the devil 174 assayes = attempts, i.e. attacks 177 longethe = belongs; clappen = clatter or prattle 183 dokked = trimmed 184 herdes = coarse flax, 'hards' 186 fette = fetched 192 hir = our? 193 rent = torn 194 shent = injured 197 lowte lowe = bow, make reverence 205 leese = lose 206 gruchche = grumble; cheese = choose 218 vnavysed = unadvised 220 doome = judgment 222 paryll = peril 223 Pourposithe him = He purposeth 231 rokkes = distaffs, also as rocking, set-backs 233 Peysing = weighing 234 tht = that 239 the Kyng wol = the king wills 242 pcesse = process 248 were leuer fetterd beon = were rather to be fettered 250 suage = s(er)vage, servitude

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